

PANKAJ TIWARI



Freedom in Sight

BHOPAL For the whole of last week, Monica Bedi was said to have been busy praying in her spartan cell in Bhopal Jail's women's ward. Amidst heavy downpour on July 16, her prayers were answered when the chief judicial magistrate's court in Bhopal pronounced her acquittal in the fake passport case for want of evidence. Her lawyer P.C. Bedi was too overwhelmed to react after the verdict. Another lawyer, Santosh Verma, who has been in the de-

fence team since the case was first registered, said, "Not a single charge could be proved."

Bedi had been charged with travelling to Lisbon with don Abu Salem on a fake passport acquired in Bhopal in 2001 in the name of Fauzia Usman. The passport could not be found nor could the prosecution prove that she had indeed travelled abroad on that visa. They couldn't even prove that she had signed the application forms.

Her defence team now

ACQUITTED: Bedi

says that the prison ordeal of the Bollywood starlet could be over as early as next week. While she was sentenced by a special CBI court in Hyderabad to five years' imprisonment in September 2006 in another forged passport case, the quantum of her term was reduced to three years by the Andhra Pradesh High Court in March this year.

An appeal against that conviction is pending in the Supreme Court which, in May, also granted her bail in the case. With her acquittal in the Bhopal case, Bedi could breathe free after the completion of some formalities in Hyderabad.

While the verdict was a setback to the Madhya Pradesh Police, there are indications that the prosecution could go in for an appeal in the High Court against the lower court's acquittal. For that, the Law Department first has to examine the merits of the case.

by Ambresh Mishra

Using Jinnah Again

AHMEDABAD Reaching the top is easy, retaining the position is difficult and Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi is learning this lesson well. With assembly polls in the state round the corner, his political rivals—both in and outside the party—are trying every trick in the book to dislodge him from the chief minister's

HEMANT CHAWLA



TRAP TIME: Modi

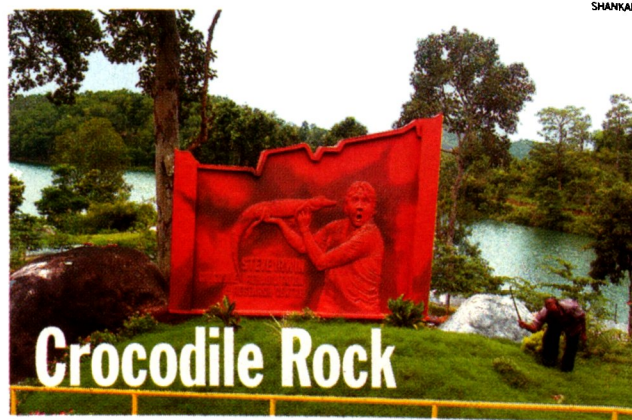
chair. And robbing him of his Hindutva image is just one of them. They have now turned to Mohammad Ali Jinnah and are hoping that he does the same to Modi what he did to former BJP president L.K. Advani.

The opportunity came when the state Government's mouthpiece *Gujarat* published an article by columnist Gunwant Shah in which he quoted Jinnah's close friend Kanji Dwarkadas as saying that he was a secularist at heart. And it is this article that has the Congress and Sangh Parivar dissidents up in arms accusing Modi of betraying the cause of Hindutva and being unpatriotic. Modi, however, has chosen to remain silent over the issue in the hope of reaping rich dividends when he replies to the poll rhetoric during peak election time.

by Uday Mahurkar

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Steve Irwin, the crocodile hunter who became famous for the television serial by the same name, has a memorial set up in the most unlikely of places. The Crocodile Rehabilitation and Research Centre at the Neyyar Wildlife sanctuary in Thiruvananthapuram has now been named after the Australian conservationist and crocodile expert who died in North Queensland when a stingray barb pierced his chest under water last year. "This is the first ever government-run centre set up in his memory," said



SHANKAR

TRIBUTE: The park is an ode to Irwin

Benoy Viswam, state forests minister opening the 2.5-hectare centre where a huge plaque of Irwin with a crocodile

greet visitors. The centre houses about 50 marshy and mugger crocodiles and is part of the 128-sq km Neyyar sanctuary which also boasts of a lion safari.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan